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MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (HONOURS) Regular EXAMINATION October 2025

Third SEMESTER

Discipline Specific Core Course (DSC) - MG3DSCHIS201 -UNDERSTANDING EARLY INDIA

(2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Scheme of Valuation

Part A

SHORT ANSWER

Answer any 10 questions

Each question carries 2 marks

1. The Indus Valley Civilization (IVC), also known as the Harappan Civilization, originated around 2500 BCE in the northwestern region of the Indian subcontinent, mainly along the Indus River and its tributaries. It was one of the world's earliest urban civilizations, alongside those of Egypt and Mesopotamia.

Major locations include:

Harappa (in present-day Pakistan's Punjab region) — one of the first sites discovered, giving the civilization its name.

Mohenjo-Daro (in Sindh, Pakistan) — notable for its advanced city planning, drainage systems, and architecture.

Other important sites include Dholavira and Lothal in present-day India.

2. During the Neolithic Age in the Indian subcontinent, people created pottery with geometric designs, terracotta figurines, and polished stone tools. Their religion focused on nature and fertility cults, including the worship of mother goddesses and animal symbols linked to agriculture and prosperity.

3. The Satavahanas ruled the Deccan region (c. 1st century BCE to 3rd century CE) after the Mauryas. Their rule was marked by strong central authority with local governors, but also some autonomy for regional rulers. They promoted trade, built roads and ports, and issued inscribed coins. The Satavahanas supported Buddhism and Brahmanism, built stupas and cave temples, and encouraged art and learning, helping to unify the Deccan culturally and economically.

4. In the Vedic period, bali referred to voluntary or obligatory offerings or tributes made by the people to their rulers. These payments, often in the form of grain, cattle, or goods, helped Vedic leaders and chiefs (rajas) gather resources to maintain their households, warriors, and priests. Over time, bali became a more regular tax, strengthening the rulers' control and supporting the growth of early political and economic organization.

5. During the Gupta period, rulers made land grants to Brahmins and officials, often exempting them from taxes. Scholars debate whether this led to Indian feudalism: One view says these grants weakened central power, as local landlords gained control over land and peasants—similar to feudal lords in medieval Europe. Another view argues the system was mainly administrative or religious, not fully feudal, since the state still retained authority. Thus, the feudalism debate centers on whether Gupta land grants marked the rise of local power or simply reflected state patronage and decentralization.

6. In the Malwa culture (around 1900–1400 BCE), improved agricultural practices—such as the use of metal tools and irrigation—led to surplus production. This surplus supported settled village life and encouraged trade and craft specialization. As a result, society became more stratified, with distinctions emerging between farmers, artisans, and elites. Thus, agriculture played a key role in shaping the economic base and social hierarchy of the Malwa culture.

7. The Indica, written by Megasthenes, a Greek ambassador in Chandragupta Maurya's court, gives a detailed account of daily life in Mauryan society. It describes a well-organized administration, orderly

cities, and people engaged in farming, trade, and crafts. Society was divided into different groups or castes, each with specific duties. Megasthenes noted the simplicity, discipline, and honesty of the people, as well as the strict laws and state control over economic activities. Overall, Indica highlights a prosperous and well-regulated Mauryan way of life.

8. Gupta stupas played a key role in spreading Buddhist ideas during the Gupta period (4th–6th century CE). These stupas, often richly decorated with sculptures and inscriptions, served as centres of worship, learning, and pilgrimage. They helped preserve Buddhist teachings, attract monks and devotees, and promote artistic expression linked to Buddhist themes. By supporting such monuments, the Guptas aided the revival and wider reach of Buddhism across India and beyond.

9. During the Gupta period, jati (sub-caste) hierarchies became more rigid and deeply influenced social roles. Each jati had specific occupations, duties, and social rules, determining people's work, marriage, and status. Mobility between jatis was limited, reinforcing social order and stability, but also gross inequality. This structure supported the varna system and reflected the growing importance of hereditary professions in Gupta society.

10. Vedic texts, especially the Rigveda, provide evidence of how Indo-Aryans settled in the north-western Indian subcontinent (modern Punjab and Haryana). The texts describe rivers like the Sarasvati and Sindhu, pastoral life with cattle rearing, and seasonal migrations for grazing. They also mention conflicts with local tribes and the establishment of early settlements and tribal assemblies (samitis), showing a gradual shift from a nomadic to a settled agricultural lifestyle in the region.

11. Buddhist teachings guided people's lives by promoting ethical conduct, mindfulness, and compassion. Core principles like the Four Noble Truths and the Eightfold Path encouraged individuals to overcome suffering through right action, speech, and thought. Buddhism emphasized non-violence, charity, and moderation, influencing daily behavior, social interactions, and moral decisions, helping people lead disciplined and harmonious lives.

12. Evidence of human evolution in the Indian subcontinent comes from fossils and stone tools found at several sites: Paleolithic sites: Bhimbetka (Madhya Pradesh) – rock shelters with stone tools and cave paintings. Homo erectus fossils: Narmada Valley – skull fragments indicating early human presence (~200,000–500,000 years ago). Mesolithic/Neolithic sites: Mehrgarh (Balochistan) – early agriculture and settled life. These finds show a continuous human presence and gradual development of tools, culture, and settlement in the subcontinent.

Part B
SHORT ESSAY
Answer any 6 questions
Each question carries 5

13. During the Vedic period, society witnessed a major shift from a primarily pastoral lifestyle to a more settled agricultural way of life. In the early Vedic phase, communities were largely nomadic, moving with their herds of cattle and relying on milk, meat, and animal products for sustenance. The Rigveda describes these pastoral practices and seasonal movements. Gradually, as people settled near fertile river valleys such as the Sarasvati, Indus, and later the Ganga, they began to cultivate crops like barley, wheat, and rice. The adoption of agriculture brought several important changes. It allowed for food surpluses, which supported larger settlements, population growth, and trade. Villages became permanent, leading to the development of social hierarchies, specialized occupations, and tribal governance. This transition laid the foundation for more complex political and economic structures in later Vedic society, marking the move from a nomadic to a settled, organized civilization.

14. The movement of Indo-Aryans from the north-western regions to the Ganga-Yamuna Doab during the later Vedic period (c. 1000–600 BCE) brought significant cultural changes. As they settled in fertile plains, their pastoral lifestyle gradually shifted toward agriculture, introducing new crops and farming techniques. This migration also influenced social organization. Tribal groups became more hierarchically structured, giving rise to early varna distinctions and jati-based occupations. The Indo-Aryans brought their language (Sanskrit), religious rituals, and Vedic texts, which spread throughout the region. They built permanent settlements, developed councils (samitis and sabhas) for governance, and began ritual sacrifices tied to agriculture, blending spiritual and economic life. Overall, their movement transformed the Doab into a region of stable villages, organized society, and rich cultural-religious traditions, laying the foundation for later kingdoms in northern India.

15. During the Gupta period (4th–6th century CE), Buddhist art and architecture reached new heights, reflecting both religious devotion and artistic excellence.

Viharas: These were monastic complexes where monks lived, studied, and meditated. Gupta viharas were spacious, well-planned, and often included courtyards, cells, and assembly halls, emphasizing simplicity and functionality.

Stupas: Gupta stupas served as relic monuments and pilgrimage sites. They were ornately decorated with sculptures depicting Buddha's life and Jataka tales, combining religious symbolism with artistic sophistication.

Cave art: Gupta cave temples, such as those at Ajanta, featured intricate murals and sculptures illustrating Buddhist teachings. The art showed naturalistic human figures, expressive emotions, and elaborate storytelling, highlighting both spiritual and aesthetic ideals. Together, viharas, stupas, and cave art during the Gupta period reflected a harmonious blend of devotion, education, and artistic innovation, promoting Buddhism while advancing Indian art and architecture.

16. The Mauryan Empire (c. 321–185 BCE) had a highly centralized and efficient administration, as outlined in Kautilya's Arthashastra. The emperor held supreme authority over the military, revenue, and justice, supported by a structured bureaucracy of ministers, officials, and provincial governors. The state collected land taxes, trade duties, and maintained monopolies to ensure steady resources, while spies, police, and strict laws upheld law and order. A well-organized standing army and intelligence network safeguarded the empire, and economic activities such as agriculture, crafts, and markets were closely regulated to promote prosperity. Overall, Kautilya's work reflects a pragmatic and well-planned system aimed at maintaining political stability, social order, and economic growth.

17. During the Gupta and post-Gupta periods, the crystallization of jati (sub-caste) hierarchies had a profound impact on social life. Each jati became associated with specific occupations, duties, and social rules, which regulated work, marriage, and community interactions. This system reinforced the broader varna structure, making social mobility limited and creating a more rigidly stratified society. Temples, guilds, and villages often reflected jati divisions, as people organized around hereditary professions and communal networks. While this structure helped maintain social stability and order, it also entrenched inequalities, shaping cultural, economic, and religious life across Gupta and post-Gupta society.

18. Yes, the South Indian Chalcolithic communities effectively utilized their environment. Settling near rivers, fertile plains, and forested areas, they practiced mixed farming, cultivating millets, pulses, and rice, and domesticated cattle, sheep, and goats. They also exploited local resources to make stone and copper tools, pottery, and beads, and engaged in hunting, fishing, and gathering to supplement their diet. Their settlements show careful planning with storage pits and mud-brick structures, indicating adaptation to local conditions. Overall, these communities demonstrated a practical and sustainable use of their natural surroundings for food, tools, and shelter.

19. Early people often chose to settle near big rivers like the Indus because rivers provided fresh water, fertile soil, and food resources. The Indus Valley Civilization (c. 2500–1900 BCE) built cities like

Harappa and Mohenjo-Daro on riverbanks, which allowed them to practice agriculture, manage water through wells and drainage, and engage in trade. Rivers also offered transport routes and fish, supporting both daily life and economic activity. Thus, proximity to large rivers guided early humans in selecting safe, resource-rich locations for permanent settlements.

20. Jainism and Buddhism, as heterodox sects, differed from Vedic orthodoxy primarily in their approach to rituals and the authority of the Vedas. Unlike Vedic tradition, which emphasized sacrificial rituals, priests, and Vedic texts, both Jainism and Buddhism rejected elaborate sacrifices and the idea that rituals alone could lead to spiritual liberation. Instead, they focused on personal ethical conduct, meditation, and self-discipline as the path to spiritual growth, marking a clear departure from Vedic ritualism.

21. In early Vedic political life, Sabha, Samiti, and Vidhata played key roles in governance and decision-making. The Sabha was a council of elders or nobles that advised the king and judged disputes. The Samiti was a larger assembly of the tribe, which participated in important decisions, including war, alliances, and the selection of leaders. The Vidhata enforced decisions on leading military campaigns, and maintaining order. Women were members of Vidhata. Together, these institutions balanced authority, consultation, and collective participation in early political organization.

22. The changing roles of Sabha, Samiti, and Vidhata show the political evolution in early Vedic times. Initially, these assemblies—the Sabha (council of elders), Samiti (general tribal assembly), and Vidhata (another deliberative body)—played active roles in decision-making, war, alliances, and leader selection. Over time, as societies became more settled and hierarchical, their influence gradually declined, and the king's authority grew, though the assemblies still functioned in advisory and ritual capacities. This shift highlights the move from collective tribal governance to more centralized political control.

Part C
SHORT ANSWER
Answer any 6 questions
Each question carries 5

23. The Mesolithic Age in India (c. 10,000–4,000 BCE) marked the transition between the Paleolithic hunter-gatherers and the Neolithic agricultural communities. People during this period were primarily hunter-gatherers, but they also practiced early animal domestication and seasonal cultivation. Tool traditions of the Mesolithic period were characterized by microliths—small, sharp stone tools often set into wood or bone to make arrows, spears, and sickles. These tools were highly versatile, reflecting advances in technology and adaptation to varied environments. In addition to microliths, people also made bone tools, grinding stones, and polished implements, which aided in hunting, food preparation, and craft production. Main sites include Bagor and Bhimbetka in Madhya Pradesh, Langhnaj in Gujarat, and Adamgarh in Maharashtra. These sites reveal rock shelters, paintings, and evidence of seasonal camps, showing that Mesolithic communities were mobile but increasingly settled near rivers and fertile lands. The rock art, especially at Bhimbetka, depicts hunting scenes, animals, and human activities, offering insight into their daily life, beliefs, and social organization. Overall, the Mesolithic Age in India represents a period of technological innovation, ecological adaptation, and cultural expression, bridging the gap between nomadic hunting societies and settled agricultural communities.

24. The Aryan Debate has three main perspectives, along with their key proponents:

Migration Theory – Suggests Indo-Aryans moved into India from Central Asia around 1500 BCE. Supported by linguistic and archaeological evidence. Prominent proponents: Max Müller, Mortimer Wheeler.
Indigenous Theory (Out-of-India) – Argues Aryans were native to India, evolving from late Harappan culture, with continuities in culture and religion. Prominent proponents: BalGangadharTilak, DayanandSaraswati, ShrikantTalageri.
Interaction/Assimilation Theory – Proposes a mix of local populations and incoming groups, emphasizing cultural exchange rather than a single migration or invasion. Prominent proponents: R.S. Sharma, RomilaThapar.
These perspectives use texts, archaeology, and linguistics to explain the Aryans' arrival and influence.

25. During the Gupta age (4th–6th century CE), systems of knowledge, literature, and religious thought were closely interconnected, reflecting a period of remarkable intellectual and cultural growth. Sanskrit literature, such as Kalidasa's poetry and dramas, combined artistic expression with philosophical and moral themes. Scientific knowledge in astronomy, mathematics, medicine, and grammar was often linked to religious and ritual practices, as seen in Aryabhatiya and SushrutaSamhita. Religious traditions—Brahmanical Hinduism, Buddhism, and Jainism—influenced literature, temple architecture, and philosophical texts, while scholarship helped systematize and spread religious ideas. This synergy of learning, art, and spirituality shaped the intellectual and cultural life of the Gupta period.

26. During the Mahajanapada period (c. 6th–4th century BCE), political structures varied between kingdoms (monarchies) and Ganasanghas (republics). Kingdoms, such as Magadha and Kosala, were monarchical, ruled by a king with centralized authority, supported by ministers and officials. Decisions were largely made by the king, though assemblies sometimes had advisory roles. In contrast, Ganasanghas, like Vajjis and Shakyas, were republican in nature, governed by assemblies of clan elders or elected representatives who made collective decisions on war, alliances, and governance. While kingdoms emphasized centralized power and hereditary rule, Ganasanghas focused on shared authority and participatory decision-making, reflecting diverse political experimentation in early India.

Special Instruction

The scheme provides a general outline but does not fully address the cognitive level targeted. Teachers should consider the Bloom's Taxonomy level of each question during valuation process.